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BEAUTY EDITOR, NEW WOMAN MAGAZINE

I've been a beauty junkie since mum first bequeathed me some pre-loved lipsticks and an Estée Lauder cleanser. Little did I know back then the sheer size of the machine that is the beauty industry, or that one day I'd be among the cog-turners that churn out those delicious bite sized pieces of luxury. The beauty pages of a magazine like New Woman are kind of like a manual to this machine, and when you consider that my readers are your customers, we're both talking to the same people.

As consumers are more beauty-savvy than ever before, they demand more from their products. They want brands that are big enough to spend a bomb on R&D, but small enough to maintain that personal charm. They want to know that every celebrity adores this product, yet they want to be the only one that knows about it. They want the latest in scientific formulations, but they're not sure they should be putting chemicals on their skin. At the end of the day they want products that do all they promise, and more, at a good price.

Beauty advertising has always driven dreams. Perfumes and beauty products

allow you to rent-an-identity, transform your appearance and in turn, your attitude. Our job in beauty writing is to help our readers (your customers) navigate an increasingly volatile and segmented market that's flooded with competitive companies and tenuous claims. As a beauty editor it's important to peel away the gloss on the press releases, see a product for what it is and to give an unbiased, honest commentary on the cosmetics world. And as we all know, the industry is not all rosy. As the grey market threatens to eclipse department store sales and cosmetic houses valiantly dream up creative counter-

attacks, it's up to all of us to keep the dream alive.

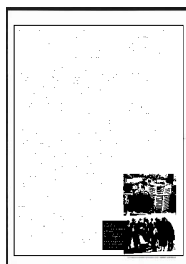
As beauty editors, one way we do this is to generate excitement around beauty on our pages. Inspired readers are enthusiastic customers. And while it may look like we spend all our time swilling champagne and playing make-up, we're actually gathering material for around 20 pages of magazine copy that need to be researched, written and photographed for each month's issue. No mean feat when we've had more launches than you can poke a lipstick at. And yep, those launches do happen to be very enjoyable, (and often involve food, bubbles and pampering), but they do have their downside (hard to believe, I know!). Being out of the office for half of your week means writing stories outside of work hours and working late nights, early mornings, weekends. But I wouldn't trade it in for anything. It's hectic and intense but a total blessing for a beauty addict. To give you an idea of the crazed crescendo that is a beauty editor's month, I'll take you on a countdown to my 'D day' (deadline day).

FOUR WEEKS TO GO

It's finger-freezing July and I'm starting work on our October issue. I'm sure you're aware of the freakish magazine 'time-space continuum' where editorial winter ends in July and Christmas happens in September. I cast my mind to that sweetly scented month when spring gently descends. We store our woolies and like snakes, we shed our scaly winter skin.

Appropriately, October is our body issue, so we'll be looking at all the glorious ways we can look and feel better just in time for bikini season. Having previously worked on a weekly mag I'm still relatively relaxed at this point. In the monthly mindset, four weeks 'til deadline is quite a happy place to be. It's time to cast the research net out far and wide to get the low down on the latest trends and innovations for achieving the body beautiful.

I start by logging onto style, health and research websites for the latest news, scanning my favourite overseas mags (e.g. Allure, UK Elle, US Vogue) for new trends and stats. I then sift through the hundreds of press releases in my inbox and pick my way through all the new beauty products that have piled up in my cupboard over the month, in between phoning various experts (dermatologists, make-up artists, cosmetic surgeons) about the latest body trends. After coming up with a list of ideas I have a meeting with our deputy editor, Natasha Silva-Jelly (a beauty buff herself, she's great to bounce ideas off). We whittle it down to a definitive list of upfront stories, regular pages and meatier features. Amongst other things I'll be doing an upfront shopping page of the latest and greatest body-blitzing products, a



practical story on beautifying the less-loved bits (back, butts, shoulders), an investigative story on the latest advancements in cellulite treatments, and more. I email a call-out requesting product and information to all the lovely beauty PRs and start getting responses immediately.

This whole process spans a few days and is peppered with a few exciting excursions. On Thursday I arrive back from lunch to several male models waiting for me at reception. The promotional guys from Nivea Lip Care have brought us cupcakes and lollies for afternoon tea and are here to launch Nivea's new Caregloss & Shine. I take them (the boys and the cupcakes) to the office for the girls to enjoy.

The next day I'm dragged to Noosa (kicking and screaming, naturally) for a Kérastase launch. Over a delicious waterfront lunch, health and 'life stylist' and author, Cyndy O'Meara talks to us about nutrition. Perfect timing for our body issue! I ask her some questions about diet and cellulite. After a stylish launch of the revived Kérastase Nutritive range, we have an amazing six course degustation dinner before retiring to our rooms.

THREE WEEKS...

On Monday morning we gather at the Boy Charlton pool in the Domain for the announcement of Covergirl's new celebrity ambassador, Jennifer Hawkins. The sun is shining and she looks so beautiful and tanned, it's easy to get in the spring mindset as I head back to the office.

Since I've been away most of the product call-ins have arrived and my desk is stacked to the ceiling with bags and boxes of products. After clearing a space to sit and only just surviving the ensuing avalanche, I select a few new products to take home and try myself as well as give a few more out to guinea pigs in the office who promise to use them religiously and deliver a verdict to me. Next I sit down to 146 emails, 22 phone messages and attempt to furiously organise some of my questions and interviews for the cellulite story. I then hit the phones to research treatments.

The next morning we have an elegant launch for La Mer at an art gallery in Woollahra. The 'miracle broth' that made their cream famous now comes in a luxurious foundation. With its surprisingly accessible price tag, I sense this will be a hit with our readers who love to get their hands on anything the stars swear by.

Back at work I call all our judges for the New Woman beauty awards to see how they're going and to invite them to judging day. This takes the better part of the morning, and I'm flat out for the rest of the day writing my next story frantically. I realise that days in the office are scarce next week so stay late to get ahead.

On Thursday it's a high tea to launch Estée Lauder's Pure White Linen at a stunning private house in Rose Bay. What a chic affair! Scattered around the bright blue pool are a string quartet, dapper waiters in white tuxedos, little cupcakes, champagne, and an ancient calligrapher writing bespoke love notes, all bathed in soft winter sunlight. I don't want to go back to the real world.

TWO WEEKS...

On Monday morning Chanel have creatively commandeered a sunlit corner at the Tropical centre in the Royal Botanic Gardens for the launch of their new Sublimage cream (which contains tropical plant extracts). As we step into the leafy greenhouse for the presentation it feels like the middle of summer. This will be perfect for a story we're doing in our twice-yearly beauty magazine, Instant Beauty, about luxe creams.

Following a frenzied Tuesday morning at the office, we're in for more treats as L'Occitane launches their Grape Seed range of body products (great for my body issue) at a day spa. I enjoy a luxuriously grape scented scrub and mask from the new range then whiz to a palatial Paddington terrace where Donna Hay teaches us how to make a variety of delish red apple recipes for the launch of DKNY'S Red Delicious. Whenever I wear that sweet fresh fragrance I'm reminded of all the beauty editors eating ourselves into a sugar high and bonding over burnt friends and crisp apple crumble. I swear beauty launches just get better and more creative every week. Such moments definitely make all the late nights bearable.

The rest of the week goes by in a blur as I attempt to make up for lost time out of the office with some late nights and super early starts. I'm shooting next week so I have to select products for my stories, which is almost impossible when there are so many good products! I test many myself and get the verdicts from my guinea pigs to make some selections. Other choices are based on price, availability, and aesthetic factors like colour and packaging. I often have a colour or style theme and liaise with the art team to make sure all the products complement one another and the layout.

ONE WEEK...

On Monday morning I head to a boardroom at the Westin to hear all about L'Oréal Professional Hairmix a funky new range of styling products for disobedient hair, then race to The Park Hyatt to interview The Body Shop's affable make-up artist extraordinaire, Chase Aston.

Other highlights? Beside sweeping views of Sydney from the Intercontinental's Ocean room, ModelCo and Lisa Ho launch a jet-set ready cosmetics bag. I dash back to the office and drum out a story on body blitzers, before heading to Christina Fitzgerald's manicure room to interview her for my mani and pedi story. Next on to The Establishment for cocktails as Crabtree & Evelyn launch a delicious new range of body products (perfect timing!).

The rest of the week is spent shooting still-life products and dashing back to my desk to finish my stories. There are a few four o'clock chocolate fixes and three very late nights but on Friday (copy is nearly all in!) I'm rewarded with a hell of a breathtaking experience. For the launch of their new Repairwear Lift cream Clinique takes us up to Centrepont Tower to do the Skywalk. If the thought of twenty beauty editors 260 metres above ground doesn't make you laugh, try picturing a group of frightened girls in delightful blue and yellow boilersuits – a far cry from the usual pencil skirt and frilly-frock flock one usually sees at launches.

I head back to the office to finish off my copy in a race against the clock. As I put my last story through I head straight into a planning meeting for November. It's set to be our biggest beauty issue ever as we announce the winners of the New Woman Beauty Awards. Watch this space!



1. An uplifting experience for Clinique's Repairwear Lift launch – the beauty girls do the Sydney Skywalk
2. Life's a beach. Kérastase presents to the beauty girls in sunny Noosa.

